Moscow. He called Khrushchev's second in command, Central Committee Secretary Frol Kozlov, who told him the reason for the urgent meeting: it was expected that Kennedy would make a major foreign policy announcement.[4]

According to the protocol of the Kremlin meeting, Khrushchev wanted to discuss "positions toward further steps in regard to Cuba and Berlin." Ironically, the official agenda echoed the title of that day's article in the *New York Herald Tribune* by Warren Rogers, "Top-Secret Doings in the Capital; A Cuba-Berlin Strategy Step?" In fact, the only item to be discussed that night in the Kremlin was Cuba. According to the protocol of the meeting and the memoirs of Mikoyan, Berlin was not mentioned even once. Mikoyan recalled that once the members of the Soviet leadership got together, they realized what was on the agenda: "We understood this had something to do with Cuba."[5]

It was close to 10:00 p.m. on October 22. By that time, the Soviet leaders already knew that Kennedy's televised address was scheduled for 7:00 p.m. EST, which would be early morning on October 23 in Moscow. They had a few hours on their hands to discuss the situation before Kennedy made his announcement. "Not yet knowing the content of the speech, we exchanged views about expected issues from the US government's positions, what steps it would take and possible countermeasures on our end," recalled Mikoyan. "Anything at all could be expected from them," he wrote, describing the tense atmosphere in the room.[6]

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KHRUSHCHEV OPENED THE MEETING AND GAVE THE FLOOR TO the minister of defense, Marshal Rodion Malinovsky. Normally a hawk when it came to Khrushchev's policies on Cuba, he was trying to calm his boss and his colleagues. Malinovsky urged them to avoid any hasty action. "I do not think that the USA right now could embark on blitzkrieg operations. It is not such a country," began Malinovsky. Instead he expected threats and suggested that Kennedy's speech was a "pre-election stunt." In the worst